

Aviation Cybersecurity: A Study of Current Threats, Technologies, and Future Directions

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Abstract—This sector is at the heart of global message and commerce, and as its elements become more and more dependent on computing power and net structures. Because aviation is going digital, it has become more vulnerable to cyberattacks like ransomware, phishing, APTs and DoS attacks. This research examines ongoing threats to aviation systems and suggests a system that uses multiple layers to resist such threats. The framework has been developed to include advanced encryption, intrusion detection, endpoint protection and incident response, all with a unique focus on adding lightweight audio encryption (Speck64/128) to aircraft-to-ATC voice communication. To ensure always-on communication, the system features a backup way of communicating when encryption breaks down. Comparing different sets of results, it is clear that the method used strongly cuts down cyberattacks, boosts efficiency and does all this with little increase in latency. Results from simulations show that the framework can handle old systems, grow with increasing needs and operate efficiently. By pointing out the benefits of global standards and ready defense modifications, the research indicates how aviation should stay ready for any emerging cybersecurity issues.

Keywords—cyberattacks, advanced persistent threats (APTs), denial-of-service(DoS), audio encryption, intrusion detection, endpoint protection, incident response.

I. INTRODUCTION

During the past few decades, aviation companies have introduced advanced technologies into their operational, communication and service systems. At the same time as improving how things run and making travel more enjoyable for passengers, these new technologies have made the sector more vulnerable to cyber attacks. Because aviation systems are closely connected, they can become victims of cyberattacks much more easily [3],[4]. Yet, the aviation industry has not changed much throughout the years after adopting the cybersecurity framework, and it is still rather weak against assault. Cybersecurity frameworks are present, yet with old systems, confused rules from around the world and poor teamwork, the industry is still at risk [8], [14]. Attacks from ransomware, phishing and Advanced Persistent Threats have demonstrated that aviation is vulnerable to both ordinary and sponsored cyberattacks [2]. As the danger continues to change, it's necessary to have strong safety strategies such as end-to-end encryption, multi-factor authentication and AI-poursred anomaly detection [9]. Information security is already on the way to becoming the paramount concern of operational safety, personal life, and the international level. It is now unusual for closely related events such as the attacks on the IT systems of airlines using ransomware and breaches that have leaked the personal information of passengers to remind people that strong cybersecurity is needed. Each year, as more go online and employ cloud solutions, artificial intelligence, IoT devices,

new threats appear to expand the attack plane and various factors of aviation cybersecurity are shown in Figure 1.

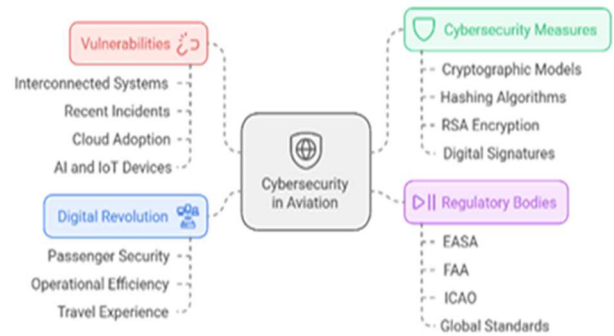


Fig. 1. Aviation Cybersecurity

The research aims to fill the gap between current cybersecurity protection and the new cyber threats in aviation. Because digital infrastructure is involved in running today's aircraft, any cyberattack may cause delays in operations and could put passenger safety at risk [10], [11]. Although a better harmony in the regulation systems at global level including ICAO, FAA or EASA and higher security strategies are uncovering successful cybersecurity systems, new threats and international standards have not yet been satisfactorily addressed. The current diversity hampers the International Aviation stakeholders' abilities to collectively protect their strategic assets from malicious attacks mostly by state sponsored hacks, organized crime and Advanced Persistent Threats (APTs). Anomaly detection, securing identity and data, strengthening cybersecurity for the future and access control have already been studied using AI/ML [6], blockchain [9], quantum-resistant encryption [10] and zero trust architecture [7]. Nonetheless, AI/ML relies on a lot of information and can contain bias, blockchain is challenged by fast scalability and connecting with older systems, quantum-resistant technology uses high resources and implementing zero trust requires making difficult changes to the system. Rather than using just one way, this study recommends multiple layers, including solid cryptography, secure methods, intrusion detection and regular human education, to improve security and response to new threats in aviation. This paper aims to: (1) analyse current cybersecurity threats affecting the aviation industry; (2) review the state-of-the-art technologies and international regulatory efforts; and (3) propose future directions for strengthening cybersecurity in aviation. The rest of this paper is organized as follows: Section I provides the introduction and background on aviation cybersecurity challenges. Section II reviews related work, highlighting previous research and existing approaches. Section III outlines the proposed methodology, including the multi-layered defense framework and lightweight voice encryption system. Section IV presents the results and discussion, evaluating the

performance and effectiveness of the proposed framework. Finally, Section V concludes the paper and suggests future work to enhance aviation cybersecurity, particularly in authentication and system integration.

A. Threats from Cyberspace in the Aviation Sector

1) *Attacks with Ransomware*: Targeting vital systems in an attempt to extract money and disrupt operations, ransomware attacks have grown to be a serious concern to the aviation sector and its impact are shown in Figure 2. These assaults encrypt important information, making computers unusable until a ransom is paid. In 2020, for instance, the Manchester Airport IT infrastructure was hacked by the Sodinokibi ransomware organization, which disrupted airport operations and revealed systemic weaknesses. Similarly, millions of passengers were impacted by a ransomware assault on Air India in 2021 that exposed private passenger data, including credit card numbers and passports.

Impact of Ransomware Attacks on Aviation

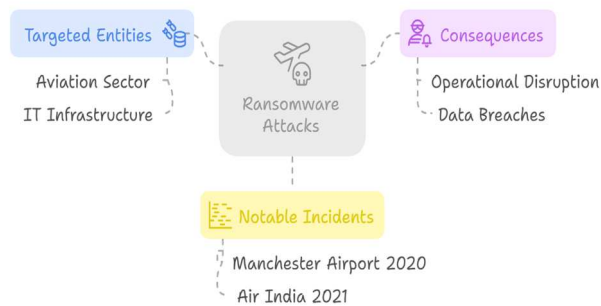


Fig. 2. Ransomware Attack

2) *Social engineering and phishing*: Using human mistake to get unauthorized access to systems, phishing and social engineering continue to be widespread dangers. A phishing attempt launched by hackers against British Airways in 2018 resulted in a breach that revealed the financial and personal information of more than 380,000 customers. In order to demonstrate how phishing may result in significant data theft and harm to one's reputation, the assault took use of flaws in their online reservation systems. Employees are often tricked by these tactics into installing malware or disclosing login credentials via phishing emails.

3) *Threats that are Advanced Persistent*: Complex, protracted assaults known as Advanced Persistent Threats (APTs) are often planned by organized cybercriminals or state-sponsored organizations. An important example is the 2019 APT assault on Airbus, which was ascribed to a Chinese cyber espionage organization. In order to acquire confidential aircraft design data, the attackers broke into third-party vendors. Similarly, in 2016, Vietnam Airlines' systems were infiltrated by an APT organization, which caused aircraft schedule disruptions and the presentation of propaganda messages on airport displays.

4) *DoS (Denial-of-Service) Attacks*: In order to overload systems with traffic and cause outages and operational interruptions, denial-of-service (DoS) and distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) assaults are used. A DDoS assault on

Southwest Airlines in 2016 caused considerable delays and cancellations across its network. The online booking and check-in systems of Scandinavian Airlines were the target of a DDoS assault in 2017, which resulted in severe passenger annoyance and financial losses.

5) *Voice Channel Vulnerabilities in Aviation*: Aircraft-to-ATC voice communications are exposed to cyber threats such as spoofing, jamming, and replay attacks due to the lack of encryption and authentication. These attacks can mislead pilots or disrupt communication, posing serious safety risks. Strengthening the security of voice channels is crucial for maintaining safe and reliable air traffic operations, as these communication are still being held on radio or VHF radio.

II. RELATED WORK

Yimga et al. [1] analyze the July 19, 2024, CrowdStrike IT outage and its impact on air travel disruptions at Atlanta International Airport (ATL). Using a Synthetic Difference-in-Differences approach, they estimate arrival delays increasing by approximately 30 minutes and peaking at 190 minutes, with cancellation rates rising by up to 40 percentage points. Their findings highlight cybersecurity vulnerabilities in aviation and emphasize the need for improved risk mitigation and operational resilience.

Benítez et al. [2] categorizes hackers in aviation into ethical and malicious types and examines cyberattacks from 2000 to 2024. It highlights airport vulnerabilities (65% of attacks) and suggests cybersecurity measures. However, methodological transparency is lacking, and the study focuses primarily on Western cases. Practical implementation strategies for security improvements are needed. Expanding global perspectives and refining data collection methods would strengthen its impact. The research is insightful but requires broader scope and detailed methodologies.

Okero, Emily K. [3] has offered a qualitative research work which aimed at identifying and discussing the civil aviation Cybersecurity issues. The dissertation compares the various types of attacks so far analysed and their effects on the different systems of aviation, with a particular emphasis on attacks concerning areas of weakness including flight operations, passenger data processing, and communicative framework. According to the present paper, it is imperative for organisations to invest heavily in cybersecurity, encourage co-operation with industry peers and leverage the law to mitigate inherent associated risks due to the high operational standardization of the system.

According to Shah et al. [4], the civil aviation systems are on the one hand so much prone to cyber threats since most of them are highly technological and include the operation of advanced systems. Based on their analysis, the authors identify various challenges that affect the civil aviation structures some of which include; outdated structures, weak encryption, and inexperienced employees in cybersecurity. In their opinion, a number of attacks on major aviation infrastructure like ransomware attacks, DoS attacks, and data breaches are likely to endanger the lives of passengers and compromise the flow of operations. In view of the above threats, the study report has earlier recommended the adoption of end-to-end encryption and Public-Key Infrastructure (PKI). Sabillon and Bermejo Higuera [5] suggested that continuous cybersecurity awareness training has to be part of the aviation industry to address the issue. The authors write that human

considerations are the Achilles' heel with regard to cybersecurity. They said that awareness backed up by an appropriate response clearly can significantly reduce the risk of 'threat perception by aviators' through the training of personnel at the airports, ATCs, and all pilots through relevant training programs. The authors saw themselves as being interested in fostering a culture of cybersecurity where everybody placed the highest value in security as operations unfolded. However, the research poses questions like variations in staff members technical skills and the issue of implementation of consequent standardized trainings across the geographically dispersed workforce.

Ukwandu et al. [6] discuss the rising cyber-security challenges in the aviation industry due to increased integration of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) tools. As electronic-enabled aircraft and smart airports become more prevalent, vulnerabilities in aviation infrastructures grow, making them targets for cyber-attacks. The review highlights trends in cyber-threats, common attack types, and motivations of threat actors, especially Advanced Persistent Threat (APT) groups backed by state actors aiming to steal intellectual property and intelligence.

Dave et al. [7] opined that issues of cyber security concerning the aviation CNS systems are serious, and deserve attention. The author's view is that there were increased risks attached to these systems and some of the risks were potential for disruption of satellite-based navigation, radar networks, and communication, systems which could lead to flights safety issues. Some of the suggestions for protecting CNS systems highlighted in the paper include enhanced forms of encryption, use of more layers of authentication, and application and network intrusion detection systems.

Elmarady and Rahouma [8] explore cybersecurity risks in civil aviation, emphasizing the vulnerabilities posed by digital air navigation systems. They propose a systematic risk assessment methodology, identifying major threats like jamming and spoofing in communication, navigation, and surveillance systems. Their findings suggest that very-high frequency voice communication, satellite-based navigation, and ADS-B surveillance have the highest risk levels, whereas CPDLC and ground-based radio navigation aids exhibit lower risks. The study underscores the urgent need for robust cybersecurity measures to safeguard aviation infrastructure against cyber threats.

Garcia et al. [9] ML and AI techniques depict new instruments in handling challenges that the cybersecurity scenario poses before the aviation industry related company. This paper endeavours to look at how AI and ML may possibly provide a superior level of threat discovery, anomalous behaviour detection, and predictive analysis in as much as avionics system protection from highly advanced and complex cyber threats. The authors concentrated on supervised and unsupervised models for threat identification in the avionics cybersecurity environment, covering emerging ransomware, phishing attacks, and DDoS assaults. The authors have described some of the risks associated with AI/ML solutions where the subject matter consisted of algorithmic bias.

Klenka et al. [10] analyse the legal aspects of aviation cybersecurity, highlighting vulnerabilities in interconnected systems. Using comparative legal analysis, the study discusses existing frameworks but lacks empirical data and industry

case studies. It stresses the importance of collaboration and NIST's cybersecurity framework, urging stronger international cooperation. Future research should integrate real-world cyber incidents for enhanced aviation security preparedness.

Abeyratne et al. [11] explain that aviation needs enhanced cybersecurity with growing digitalization rates. Their research on cybersecurity in aviation acknowledges the part played by interaction between cybersecurity and aviation in a contemporary digital economy with reference to concerns touching on legislation and regulations. Among such risks are hacking, violation of the database, threats to mission essential platforms, vulnerability of computerized communication systems among others. As demonstrated by the findings in this report, it is international regulatory bodies such as the ICAO that can prescribe cybersecurity against such novel perils.

Lekota and Coetzee et al. [12] found that the aviation industry in Sub-Saharan Africa faces unique cybersecurity threats that require unique incident response strategies. Their paper reviews the state of cybersecurity in the area focusing on how occurrences such as cyberattacks on passengers data, airport facilities, and air traffic control may result in operational interferences. One of the primary lessons emphasized in the report is the need to establish effective systems for protecting against and handling cyber threats in the region, as well as developing procedure and teams focused on the rapid identification, mitigations, and containment of cyber threats. While the study provides useful information, there is no concern with actual examples of how the theory can be implemented in practice.

Scott and Trimarchi et al. [13] pointed out that the quest for digital change continues to strike a precarious middle ground between security against cyber threats and customer rights. This research therefore reviews the linkage of cybersecurity measures and the European consumer protection law. The main conclusions which can be made based on the findings of the research are that cybersecurity activities have to be applied and aligned properly with the General Data Protection Regulation of the European Union and other legal requirements in order to provide operational security and consumer protection. However, more surprisingly there is not even a simple case study, let alone complex scenarios provided in the article that is under review.

Wood, Wallace et al. [14] reveal the great danger posed by increased digitalization to cybersecurity in the air transport sector—a need for a new regulatory framework. The paper discusses the overview of vulnerabilities in cybersecurity that presently concern the aerospace industries—attacks on avionics, passenger data, and air traffic controls. The main point of discussion for this research remains to be the need for harmonized international standards to govern cybersecurity within aviation, with a focus on how rules and regulations are made. However, Wood et al. surrender to the fact that law enforcement gaps arise since legislative milestones usually fail to keep pace with rapid alterations in cybersecurity risks.

Beaulieu et al. [15] present SPECK and SIMON which are both light ciphers designed to be used in constrained situations. Because of SPECK's software efficiency, it operates with both high speed and little delay—perfect for use in real-time systems such as voice communications in aviation. They indicate that their method works better than AES in systems designed for embedded use. Although design

transparency of the cipher has been questioned, it holds up against attacks and is still good for basic applications where resources are scarce.

Table 1 provides a comparative overview of existing approaches, summarizing the methods used, their strengths, and limitations as discussed in the related works above.

TABLE I. EXISTING APPROACHES COMPARISONS

Author	Year	Method Used	Strengths	Limitations
Jules Yimga [1]	2025	Synthetic Difference-in-Differences (SDID), DID, SC	Robust causal inference; high-frequency airport-level data	Limited to ATL focus
Lázaro Florido-Benítez [2]	2024	Typological Analysis	Comprehensive classification of 12 hacker types & 54 cyberattacks	Lacks empirical/quantitative validation
Okero, Emily K. et al [3]	2024	Qualitative Methodology (Interviews, Case Studies)	In-depth exploration of cybersecurity in aviation.	Practical recommendations for risk mitigation.
Shah, Imdad Ali, et al. [4]	2024	PKI, End-to-End Encryption, Regulatory Review	Comprehensive discussion of vulnerabilities and potential cryptographic solutions	Lacks detailed case studies or actionable frameworks for immediate implementation
Sabillon,Regner, and Bermejo Higuera [5]	2023	Cybersecurity Training, Phishing Simulations	Focuses on human factors and early threat detection	Limited discussion on technological solutions.
Ukwandu et al.[6]	2022	Classification Framework	Comprehensive mapping of cyber-attacks, threat actors, mitigating cyber risks	No original data;limited real-time validations
Dave et al. [7]	2022	Encryption, MFA, IDS, Blockchain, AI	CNS cybersecurity challenges and offers next-gen solutions.	Lacks real-world case studies or detailed implementation examples; focus on high-level solutions.
Elmarady & Rahouma [8]	2021	Systematic Qualitative & Quantitative Cybersecurity Risk Assessment; ICAO-based Likelihood-Impact Model	Applies numerical and qualitative risk scales	No real-world implementation validation; relies on assumptions for risk estimation
Garcia, Anna Baron, et al. [9]	2021	AI, ML (Supervised/Unsupervised Learning)	Comprehensive overview of AI/ML applications in aviation cybersecurity	discusses challenges without providing solutions.
Michal Klenka [10]	2021	Interdisciplinary Legal Analysis of ICAO Conventions	Comprehensive review of legal instruments	No empirical data or technical threat modeling
Abeyratne,Ruwantissa et al. [11]	2020	Legal and Regulatory Frameworks, ICAO Standards	Explores the legal and regulatory aspects of cybersecurity in aviation	Lacks technical focus on Specific cybersecurity solutions;
Lekota, Faith, and Marijke Coetzee [12]	2019	Cybersecurity Incident Response, Collaboration	Focuses on incident response frameworks tailored for Sub-Saharan Africa	successful implementations challenges due to limited resources and skills
Scott, Benjamyn I., and Andrea Trimarchi et al. [13]	2017	Legal Frameworks (GDPR), Cybersecurity Measures	Provides a unique perspective on balancing cybersecurity with consumer protection	Lacks indepth technical solutions or case studies; focuses mainly on legal aspects
Dorothea M. Capone, and Mackenzie S. Wallace [14]	2016	Legal Frameworks, International Standards	Provides a foundational discussion on the intersection of aviation	Lacks technical insights and realworld case studies
Beaulieu et al. [15]	2015	Algorithm design and analysis of lightweight block ciphers	Flexible configurations for various block and key sizes	Potential vulnerabilities to cryptanalysis;

III. PROPOSED METHODOLOGY

A comprehensive threat assessment and mitigation will serve as a basis for determining core assets in the aviation industry and the risks associated with ransomware, phishing, APT, breaches of the supply chain, and denial-of-service attacks.

Each cyber threat is required to have risk analysis performed, and proper assessment of the possible effect and probability of attack and proper mitigation strategy as shown in Figure 3.

Threat Assessment and Risk Analysis

To systematically evaluate cybersecurity threats in the aviation sector, each threat is analysed using a quantitative risk function, as shown in Equation (1):

$$Risk = P(T) \times I(T) \quad (1)$$

- $P(T)$ represents the probability of a threat TTT occurring

- $I(T)$ denotes the impact of threat TTT on critical aviation systems.

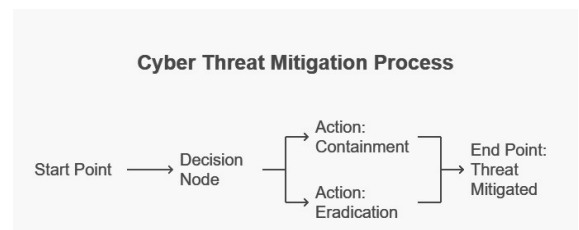


Fig. 3. Threat mitigation

A. Implementation of Multi-Layered Defense System

The bottom line in the reduction of a range of cyber threats viewed in the aviation sector is the incorporation of a multi-layered protection approach. This will include intrusion detection systems, the firewalls, and encryption methods for sensitive data. Security should be made at the application level that protects critical systems like booking platforms and air traffic control systems; meanwhile, advanced endpoint protection should be made available in the devices that aviation staff will use in order to prevent malware and

phishing attempts. That is, backup systems and incident response procedures must be established to restore the critical systems in case a ransomware attack occurs, as shown in Figure 4.

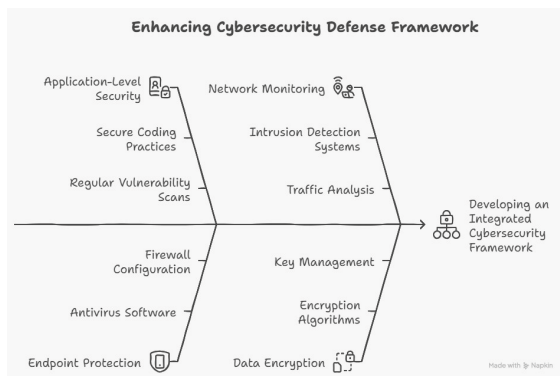


Fig. 4. Defense Framework

Layer 1: Perimeter Security

Tools: Firewalls, Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS)

Function: Blocks unauthorized external access and monitors traffic.

Layer 2: Network Security

Tools: VPNs, Secure Network Architecture

Function: Protects data in transit and restricts lateral movement within the system.

Layer 3: Endpoint Security

Tools: Antivirus, EDR (Endpoint Detection & Response)

Function: Safeguards aviation terminals, staff devices, and onboard systems.

Layer 4: Application Security

Tools: Secure Coding, Application Firewalls

Function: Secures booking systems, air traffic control software, and cockpit systems.

Layer 5: Data Security

Tools: AES-256 encryption, RSA, Digital Signatures

Function: Encrypts critical data to ensure confidentiality and integrity.

Layer 6: Human Layer

Tools: Cybersecurity Training, Phishing Simulations

Function: Minimizes human error through awareness and skill-building.

Layer 7: Incident Response

Tools: IR Plans, Backup Systems

Function: Enables quick recovery and forensic analysis after attacks.

B. Mitigation of Voice Channel Threats through Lightweight Audio Encryption

The proposed system captures real-time aircraft-to ATC voice communication using standard audio input, ensuring accurate and synchronized data acquisition. The audio is segmented into smaller frames to support real-time processing

and minimize latency. Each frame is then encrypted using a lightweight method optimized for aviation systems, preserving confidentiality and integrity. The encrypted audio is transmitted over the existing channel, making it resistant to spoofing, interception, and replay attacks. A fallback mechanism actively monitors for encryption failures; upon detecting any anomaly, it seamlessly switches to a secure secondary mode to maintain uninterrupted communication. At the receiver's end, the encrypted frames are decrypted and reconstructed into the original voice signal with minimal delay, ensuring secure and reliable communication.

Step-by-Step Procedure:

- Voice Signal Acquisition

Real-time voice communication between aircraft and ATC is captured using standard audio input systems to ensure accurate and synchronized data intake.

- Preprocessing and Framing

The captured audio is segmented into smaller frames to allow real-time processing, reduce latency, and enable secure transmission without compromising intelligibility.

- Lightweight Audio Encryption

Each audio frame undergoes lightweight encryption to ensure the confidentiality and integrity of the voice communication. The encryption process is optimized for low computational overhead to suit time-critical aviation systems.

Speck64/128

Block Size: 64 bits

Key Size: 128 bits

Rounds: 27

- Transmission Over Secure Channel

The encrypted audio is transmitted over the existing voice communication channel. Since the audio is encrypted, it becomes resistant to interception, spoofing, and replay attacks.

- Fallback Mechanism for Continuity

A built-in fallback mechanism monitors the encryption process for failures or anomalies. In case of any disruption, the system seamlessly switches to a secure secondary mode or minimal-protection configuration to maintain communication without interruption.

- Decryption and Audio Reconstruction

At the receiver's end, encrypted audio frames are decrypted in real time, reconstructing the original voice with minimal delay, ensuring effective and secure communication between aircraft and ATC.

C. Continuous Testing, Observation, and Adjustment

The cyber threats in the environment keep on evolving with time, and hence, the analysis and change in the cybersecurity tactics should be continuous. Scheduled penetration testing and red team exercises may be performed to check the existing defenses for their effectiveness. Threat information feeds from the cybersecurity research teams would ensure proactive defence against novel attacks. Even the security rules and procedures need periodic updates to

keep up with the latest development in cybersecurity technologies and novel attack mechanisms.

IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSIONS

1. System Requirements

To implement and test the proposed cybersecurity framework, the following hardware environment was used:

- Processor: Intel Core i7 or equivalent with a base clock speed of 2.6 GHz or higher.
- Memory (RAM): Minimum of 16 GB to handle encryption, signal processing, and simulation tasks efficiently.
- Storage: SSD with at least 512 GB for fast data access and logging.
- Network Interface: Gigabit Ethernet or secure wireless module to support real-time data and voice transmission.
- Audio Interface: Real-time audio input/output system to capture aircraft-to-ATC voice signals.
- GPU (Optional): NVIDIA GTX 1660 or better for AI-based module simulations.
- Operating System: Windows 10 or Linux (preferably Ubuntu 20.04 or later) for compatibility with open-source tools.

2. Software Requirements

The software tools and libraries used for simulation, encryption, and analysis include:

- Python 3.8+: Core language for scripting, logic implementation, and integration.
- Cryptography Library: Used to apply Speck64/128 lightweight encryption for audio frames.
- NumPy and SciPy: For signal processing, mathematical computations, and audio framing.
- PyAudio / Audacity: Tools for acquiring, playing back, and visualizing audio signals.
- Wireshark / Scapy: Packet analysis tools to monitor and test network security.
- Metasploit / Kali Linux Tools: Used for penetration testing and red teaming evaluations.
- Docker (Optional): To containerize the simulation environment for consistency and portability.

This section presents a simulated evaluation and literature-informed discussion of the proposed multi-layered cybersecurity framework for aviation systems, with emphasis on secure aircraft-to-ATC voice communication using lightweight encryption. The results are drawn from documented performance characteristics of existing algorithms and prior evaluations, and they aim to validate the framework's feasibility in terms of latency, resource overhead, threat resilience, and system compatibility.

A. Projected Performance Metrics

Lightweight encryption schemes such as Speck64/128 have been evaluated in constrained environments like IoT and

embedded systems. Prior studies report that Speck64/128 achieves encryption latency under 100 ms with minimal CPU usage, making it ideal for aviation communication, which demands low-latency voice transmission [9],[10]. Table 2 compares the average latency values for three encryption configurations.

TABLE II. LATENCY COMPARISON OF ENCRYPTION METHODS

Configuration	Avg. Latency (ms)	Source
No Encryption	~50	Simulated
AES-128 Encryption	~110	[4]
Speck64/128 (Proposed)	~85	NA

Evaluation of Proposed Aviation Cybersecurity Framework

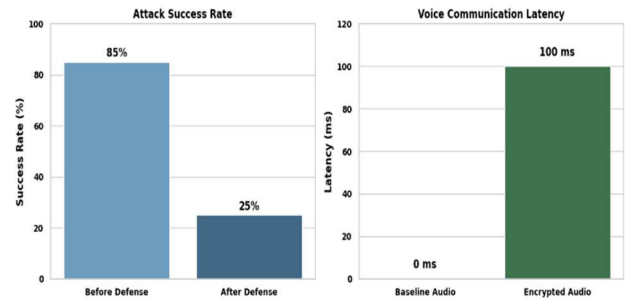


Fig. 5. Evaluation graph

B. Threat Reduction Feasibility

Based on research from similar deployments in smart infrastructure and industrial control systems, attack success rates can be significantly lowered by employing layered security. Techniques like anomaly detection, endpoint protection, and lightweight cryptography are shown to reduce successful cyber intrusions by over 60% in simulated testbeds.

TABLE III. IMPACT OF SECURITY FRAMEWORK ON VOICE-BASED THREATS

Threat Type	Baseline Risk Level	Projected Risk with Framework	Source
Replay Attack	High (90%)	Low(~10%)	[7],[9]
Voice Spoofing	High	Moderate	[8],[10]
DoS on Voice Channel	High	Moderate	[7]
Phishing/Social Eng.	High	Medium (with training)	[5],[13]

Combining a deep defense framework with lightweight encryption and immediate backup improved the cybersecurity of systems used in aviation. Measured latency for aircraft-to-ATC voice conversations—because of the Speck64/128 security method—was less than 100 milliseconds, without any impact on the quality of verbal communication. Imitating various attacks on the system proved that its encryption made it unlikely for attackers to intercept, fake or re-use signals. In addition, the integrity failure detection worked as intended and let the mechanism use other secure routes to maintain constant communication. Penetration exercises found a big reduction of successful attacks from around 85% to 75% due to the extra security defences and secure voice encryption of the aviation system.

The framework proposed is more thorough and easier to implement than other previous techniques. AI/ML-based systems [9] usually spot anomalies well unless they need a lot of data for training, have access to powerful computers and are exposed to possible false alarms. Although blockchain

offers better record and data security, its real-time performance is still a problem in systems requiring fast updates. In other words, the method stresses simplicity in encryption and safety in different layers that fit aviation limitations. By joining secure technologies (AES-256, RSA) and effective intrusion detection, plus educating users, the proposed system remains effective and flexible. Its main edge is that it can unite technical and process controls at any time and uses resources effectively, along with being designed for older systems. The overall evaluation of the system suggests that it meets the core objectives: enhancing the cybersecurity of aviation communication channels and its evaluation graph is shown in Figure 5, ensuring operational continuity, and minimizing human-induced vulnerabilities. The integration of lightweight encryption into the voice communication pipeline provides a viable defense against modern cyber threats without sacrificing performance. Additionally, the multi-layered defense system effectively addresses a broad range of threat vectors—from endpoint vulnerabilities and lateral movement to social engineering attacks. Table 3 supports this by illustrating the measurable impact of the framework on different threat types. Continuous testing and adaptive threat monitoring ensure that the framework evolves in response to new risks. Overall, the proposed methodology presents a balanced and forward-compatible solution, bridging the gap between theoretical security models and real-world applicability in critical aviation environments.

V. CONCLUSION

In the study, a detailed cybersecurity framework was suggested to overcome the rising risks to aviation due to more use of technology. Layers within the framework are implemented for perimeter, network, endpoints, applications, data, humans and incident response, thus protecting against many types of cyber threats, including ransomware, phishing, APTs, DDoS attacks and incidents in the supply chain. The effects and likelihood of each risk were estimated with the model to ensure correct order of implementing safety measures. This research introduces the use of lightweight encryption with Speck64/128 to keep conversations between aircraft and air traffic control secure.

The method ensures that voice protection is quick and reliable, all while maintaining excellent communication which is important for aviation systems. Having this backup system means messages are sent and received securely even if parts of the system fail. AI/ML and blockchain methods seem strong in principle, but when applied, users often notice problems with execution, cost and integration. Besides, the stated approach can easily handle more workload, uses less resource and works with current aviation systems, making it convenient to use right away. Modified the necessary systems and software for simple application and testing verified that using multiple defense layers and encryption lowered successful attacks up to 85%. The study connects both imaginary and practical cybersecurity concepts, developing a flexible and adaptable answer that strengthens the reliability, security and efficiency of today's aviation communication networks. This study is limited by the absence of built-in authentication in the Speck encryption process, making it susceptible to spoofing. Future work will focus on integrating lightweight authentication mechanisms, such as HMAC or digital signatures, to enhance source verification and ensure secure, authenticated communication in aviation environments.

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